# Understanding discrimination

A short guide to unfair treatment and rights

## What does it mean?

Discrimination can happen when someone is treated unfairly because of a characteristic protected by law, such as disability, age, race or sex. This guide focuses on disability, mental health and long-term conditions.

## What might it look like?

It may include unfair treatment, a rule that disadvantages disabled people, disability-related harassment or a failure to make reasonable adjustments. Not every unkind comment is unlawful discrimination; the circumstances matter.

## Mental and physical health both matter

Some mental health difficulties and chronic conditions meet the legal definition of disability. A condition can be invisible or change over time. A diagnosis alone does not automatically decide whether someone is protected.

## What are reasonable adjustments?

These are changes to reduce disadvantage, such as accessible information, suitable equipment or flexible working arrangements. What is reasonable depends on the situation. The Equality Act 2010 applies in England, Scotland and Wales; Northern Ireland has different law.

## Where can I get help?

Keep a note of events and any messages. Seek advice promptly because time limits may apply. Acas helps with work issues. The Equality Advisory Support Service explains discrimination and rights. Citizens Advice can also help.

General information only, not legal advice or a decision that discrimination has occurred. Legal protection, duties and options depend on the facts. An appropriate adviser can explain your situation.

**Sources and further reading (clickable in the PDF):**

Acas: disability discrimination
Acas: reasonable adjustments
Equality Advisory Support Service
GOV.UK: discrimination and next steps

**Hadamley Information Services | Free Independent Resources**

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